Manipur, the militants unleashed a reign of terror in the Imphal Valley, killing Indian security personnel as well as suspected ‘traitors’ to its cause. Banks were looted and weapons snatched from police stations and other outposts. Evidently inspired by the regular Chinese military, the name of the new rebel group was the People’s Liberation Army. In 1979, it formed a political wing called the Revolutionary People’s Front, led by Nameirakpam Bisheswar Singh, one of the militants who underwent training in Lhasa in 1976.

According to a classified Chinese document entitled ‘China Should Become the Arsenal for World Revolution’ and dated 7 July 1967, Mao declaimed, ‘The present situation is excellent. Nagaland in India is fighting against the Congress Party with armed struggle.’[65] Mao went on to stress the importance of the Communist Party of Burma (CPB). ‘The geographic conditions in Burma are better than those of Vietnam, with more room to manoeuvre … it is all better if the Burmese government chooses to oppose us; I hope it will sever normal relations with us. In that case, we can more openly support the Burmese Communist Party.’[66]

In the same speech, Mao went on to say, ‘China is not only the centre of world revolution, it must also be the centre of world revolution militarily and technically. When we give weapons, they will be Chinese weapons engraved with Chinese characters (except those to certain specific areas). We will support them openly; and China must become the arsenal for world revolution.’[67] India, naturally, was not pleased. India protested and pictures of weapons bearing Chinese markings that had been seized from Naga rebels were shown at the United Nations in New York. But China did not care, it was the centre of world revolution and India had become the enemy.

In 1960, Zhou Enlai had said in a speech before China’s legislature, the National People’s Congress, that, ‘we place ardent hopes in friendly relations between China and India…we deeply believe that the traditional friendship between the people’s of China and India will shine forth brilliantly to the end’.[68] However, in an internal party report from December 1971, he was more explicit and perhaps more honest and forthcoming when it came to defining his views on China’s relations with India.